ACCULTURATIVE STRESS, SELF-ESTEEM, AND EMOTIONAL WELL-BEING AMONG LATINA ADOLESCENTS

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INTRODUCTION

- Acculturative stress is the tension felt to adapt to a new culture (Roche & Kuperminc)
- Acculturative stress has been shown to be related to emotional well-being among Latinos, specifically females (Romero, et al., 2007)
- Acculturative stress includes different types of stressors, such as stressors in family relationships, discrimination, language use, and peer relationships (Roberts & Romero, 2003)
- Research has found that US born youth, compared with non-US born youth, reported more stress from needing better Spanish or from their culture keeping them from being like other Americans (Roberts & Romero, 2003)
- Studies have also found that biculturalism is related to higher self-esteem because of the ability to interact with more diverse groups and better psychological well-being (Smokowski et al.,2006)
- There is an existing gap exploring acculturative stress and emotional well-being among adolescent girls

STUDY AIMS

To explore the relationships among acculturative stress, self-esteem, depressive symptoms, anxiety, and hopelessness among Latina adolescents

METHODS

Participants

24 female adolescents ages 14 to 17 (M=15.16), recruited from two urban high schools, participated in this pilot study and completed an online self-report questionnaire

Measures

- Bicultural Stress Scale (Roberts and Romero, 2003), 20 items, 5-point scale (0-Does not apply to 4-Very stressful), internal consistency α=.84
- Depression Anxiety Stress Scale (DASS; S. Lovibond & P. Lovibond, 1995), 42 items, 3 subscales (depression, anxiety, and stress), 4-point scale (0-Not at all to 3-Most of the time)
- Adapted Hopelessness Scale for Children (HPLS; Kazdin, Rodgers, & Colbus,1986) , 6 items, agree or disagree responses, added question ("I don't expect to live a very long life")
- Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale (RSES; Rosenberg, 1965), 10-items, 4-point scale (0-Strongly disagree to 3-Strongly agree)

Data Analysis

- Descriptive statistics
- Correlation analyses; Spearman correlations run (data not normally distributed)
- Subsequent analyses run with data adjusted for acculturative stress

RESULTS

- Participants reported low levels of acculturative stress, moderate levels of self-esteem, and low levels of depressive symptoms, hopelessness, and anxiety (see Table 1 and 2)
- Adjusted for acculturative stress, a negative correlation persisted between self-esteem and depressive symptoms [$r_s(22) = -.77$, $p<.0001$] and hopelessness [$r_s(21) = -.60$, $p<.0032$] (see Table 3)

Table 2. Stress and Emotional Well-being Variable Means	Mean Scores (N=24)	Mean level of stress (girls reporting at least one stressor)
ACCULTURATIVE STRESS		
Family stressors	M= 1.73	M= 1.88 (n=20)
Discrimination	M= 1.79	M= 2.00 (n=19)
Language use	M= 1.5	M= 1.71 (n=17)
Peer pressures	M= 1.18	M= 1.43 (n=10)
	Mean Scores (N=24)	Range
SELF ESTEEM	M= 2.78	0-3
DEPRESSIVE SYMPTOMS	M= 0.68	1-4
ANXIETY	M= 0.44	1-4
HOPELESSNESS	M=0.18	0-1

Table 1. Spearman Correlation Coefficients

	ACCU_STRESS	HOPELESS	DASS_DEP	DASS_ANX	SELF_EST
ACCU_STRESS	1.00000	0.08972	-0.00832	0.20724	-0.15393
ACCU_STRESS		0.6839	0.9692	0.3312	0.4727
	24	23	24	24	24
HOPELESS	0.08972	1.00000	0.33540	0.07680	-0.60361
HOPELESS	0.6839		0.1177	0.7276	0.0023
	23	23	23	23	23
DASS_DEP	-0.00832	0.33540	1.00000	0.60018	-0.75907
DASS_DEP	0.9692	0.1177		0.0019	<.0001
	24	23	24	24	24
DASS_ANX	0.20724	0.07680	0.60018	1.00000	-0.39965
DASS_ANX	0.3312	0.7276	0.0019		0.0530
	24	23	24	24	24
SELF_EST	-0.15393	-0.60361	-0.75907	-0.39965	1.00000
SELF_EST	0.4727	0.0023	<.0001	0.0530	
	24	23	24	24	24

Table 3. Adjusted for Acculturative Stress

Method	Statistics	Hopelessness	Depression	Anxiety
Spearman	Correlation Coefficient	-0.59934	-0.76955	-0.38044
	P-value	0.0032	<.0001	0.0733



DISCUSSION

- Latina adolescents experienced moderately low levels of acculturative stress but did report stressors in all four categories
- It is possible these girls have additional protective factors not assessed in this study
- Discrimination is a leading cause of acculturative stress
- Self-esteem is a key protective factor for Latina adolescents, particularly for depressive symptoms and hopelessness
- It is possible internalizing self-worth, such as self-esteem or self-efficacy, can significantly minimize the negative outcomes of stressors, including acculturative stressors such as discrimination

Limitations

- Small sample size limits generalizability; our study did not differentiate US and non-US born youth
- Future larger studies should build on this pilot study and continue to explore the relationship of stressors, self-esteem, and emotional well-being

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